



Organizational logic and feminist organizing: stewardesses for women's rights

Donna Boone Parsons

*Department of Management and Accountancy,
University of North Carolina Asheville, Asheville, North Carolina, USA*

Kathy Sanderson

*Faculty of Business Administration, Lakehead University, Thunder Bay,
Canada, and*

Jean Helms Mills and Albert J. Mills

Sobey School of Business, Saint Mary's University, Halifax, Canada

Abstract

Purpose – Joan Acker proposed her gendered theory of organization as a framework to analyze organizations and to understand how gender underlies organizational structure in such a way as to subordinate women. Much of the previous work that has utilized this framework has examined highly (male-) gendered organizations. This archival case study aims to use Acker's framework to examine a purportedly female-gendered organization – the 1970s feminist organization, Stewardesses for Women's Rights (SFWR).

Design/methodology/approach – Using these archived materials, this paper uses a critical hermeneutic approach across Acker's framework of gendered organization to make sense of the rise and fall of SFWR. The paper discusses lessons learned from this short-lived organization.

Findings – The paper finds that societal pressure and organizing women's understanding of what is "real" and valued in an organization pushed them to create an organization that was as highly (male) gendered as the organizations from which they were escaping. Many in the organization never saw SFWR as a "real" organization because of the underlying organizational logic that was directing what the organization should be. Even if the organization did, on the surface, look different than other explicitly male-gendered organizations, the same underlying organizational logic manifested itself in similar organizational structure.

Originality/value – This archival case study uses Acker's framework to examine a purportedly female-gendered organization – the 1970s feminist organization SFWR and reveals lessons learned.

Keywords Gendered organizations, Organizational logic, Feminist organizing, Gendered substructure, Organizational structures, Feminism, Human rights, Women

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

Joan Acker's work provided a much-needed theoretical framework through which the usually invisible gendering of organizations can be understood. Acker proposed her gendered theory of organization (Acker, 1992) as a framework to analyze organizations and to understand how gender underlies organizational structure in such a way as to

The authors would like to thank the Social Sciences and Humanities Council of Canada for a grant (no. 2007-2010) to pursue this research.



subordinate women (Acker, 1990). Much of the previous work that has utilized this framework has examined highly (male-) gendered organizations. This archival case study uses Acker's framework to examine a purportedly female-gendered organization – the 1970s feminist organization, Stewardesses for Women's Rights (SFWR).

Stewardesses for Women's Rights (SFWR) was founded in 1972 by two flight attendants for Eastern Airlines as a continuation to their legal challenge against Eastern alleging discrimination in weight and grooming regulations. The organization's stated purpose at its founding was to "address working conditions and discrimination within the airline industry" (New York University Libraries, 2005). The Constitution of Stewardesses for Women's Rights affirms that "the purposes of SFWR are to fight sexual and racial discrimination and to ensure that women are given equal employment and promotional opportunities" (TAM). Although SFWR folded in 1976, several members collected and donated internal organizational documents to the New York University's Tamiment and Wagner Libraries Collections. Subsequently, a series of video-taped interviews with SFWR founders was conducted and donated to the collections.

Using these archived materials, this paper uses a critical hermeneutic approach across Acker's framework of gendered organization to make sense of the rise and fall of SFWR. We examine four sets of gendering processes and the underlying organizational logic of SFWR. We discuss lessons learned from this short-lived organization, and we suggest areas for future research using Acker's analytic framework.

Joan Acker's framework

Acker (1990) suggests that gendering occurs in five sets of processes in organizations. These processes are analytically distinct, and as such, we will examine each of them separately. However, each of them is part of the same gendered reality. This framework is consistent with the hermeneutic circle which suggests that you must examine the parts to understand the whole and the whole to fully understand the parts (Prasad and Mir, 2002). In later work, Acker presents four sets of gendering processes that occur in organizations. The fifth set of processes, organizational logic, is presented in this later version as a manifestation of the gendered substructure (Acker, 1992). For a detailed analysis of the significance of Acker's organizational logic see Dye and Mills in this collection.

According to Acker, gender is very difficult to "see" because it is almost invisible when only the masculine is present, as is the case in most organizations. As such, masculine becomes the normal or the "real", and these gendered processes become invisible (Acker, 1990). However, these gendering processes can be found in both male- and female-dominated organizations (Britton, 1999). Other work has used the Acker framework to examine organizations in male-dominated environments (e.g. Pini and Crawford, 2006; Price, 2008; Shortall, 2001) or to contrast a male-dominated and a female-dominated environment (Britton, 1997). However, we propose to utilize this framework to make sense of an all-female, feminist organization.

Methodology

Critical hermeneutics is an appropriate methodology for this research for several reasons. First, for the purposes of this project, the data from the SFWR archives was

considered as text, in the broadest sense of the term. Critical hermeneutics is a valuable method for surfacing gender that is embedded within a range of texts (McLaren and Mills, 2008). Second, because this organization existed as part of the second-wave feminist social movement of the time, this research requires a context-sensitive approach to analysis (Grant *et al.*, 2004). Finally, critical hermeneutic analysis goes beyond interpretation to attempt to uncover “the relations of power and domination that go into the very formation of text” (P. Prasad, 2005, p. 34). This is accomplished through understanding of authorship in context (i.e. making sense of what the author meant at the time) and exploring the ways that text comes to represent a dominant voice or voices, to the exclusion of other voices (A. Prasad and Mir, 2002). Using a framework of gendered organizational analysis seeks to uncover the processes and structures through which gender serves as a basis for subordination and power.

Hermeneutic interpretation is an iterative process where the parts are continually related back to the whole and visa versa (Hirschman, 1990). Based on this idea of the hermeneutic circle, that the part can only be understood from the whole and the whole can only be understood from the part (A. Prasad and Mir, 2002), this paper seeks to understand not only the text, but also the cultural context in which these texts were created. This analysis of the text required an iterative process where the analysts moved between the text, the historical context and, also, the theoretical framework to make sense of the data.

Our approach was to seek to first understand the context and authorship of the text as a means to illuminate whose interest is served. Our hermeneutic analysis was concerned with text at the symbolic level (A. Prasad and Mir, 2002). According to Dilthey, text intends ideal meanings (Klemm, 1983). The hermeneutic tradition holds that texts are cultural artifacts that represent the values and beliefs of those who created them (Dilthey, 1976). Dilthey also contended that meaningful analysis of a text calls for an understanding of the culture and context in which the text was created. In order to understand the text, one must study and understand the organizational structure and culture that produced it (Dilthey, 1976). Because history is an important part of the context, this type of investigation also requires that the researcher become familiar with the historical context in which the text was produced (A. Prasad, 2002). Both the historical and the organizational context are also important in the study of gender in organizations because the ideas of masculinity and femininity in an organization are socially constructed in the historical context and the structure of the organization (Mills, 1998). Understanding the organizational context and structure and the historical context was also essential to applying Acker’s framework.

Finally, a critical approach demands not only an external examination of the contexts, but also introspection from the researchers. The researchers must continuously examine their own constructions in order to recognize what Gadamer called “unproductive prejudices” (Gadamer, 1975, p. 263). Hermeneutic interpretation assumes the researcher’s frame of reference as a tool in the research rather than as an impediment to understanding (Hirschman, 1990). Therefore, the interpreter will be arguing only one view (his or hers) of the text (A. Prasad and Mir, 2002).

The gendered sub-structure of a feminist organization

Gender is an elemental part of the ongoing processes in an organization (Acker, 1990). Acker describes four processes of gendering that happen through concrete

organizational activities to create the gendered sub-structure. These four sets of processes are the visible manifestations of gender that are both produced by and produce the almost-invisible gender substructure. This substructure lies in the organizational logic (Acker, 1992). These processes “although analytically distinct, are, in practice, parts of the same reality.” (Acker, 1990, p. 146). As such, we will examine each set of processes individually and then as a whole.

Gender divisions

This first set of processes refers to the institutionalized maintenance of a gendered pattern of jobs, hierarchies, power and subordination in an organization (Acker, 1990, 1992). While Acker contends that this process is usually very easy to observe (Acker, 1990), this is not necessarily the case with a feminist organization. Gender divisions in an all female organization are, perhaps, seen in the types of behaviors that are valued in the organization. Because masculinity is valued in society as a whole, characteristics that are attributed to the essentialized female will be valued less than those essentially masculine characteristics (West and Zimmerman, 1987). There is a large body of literature that suggests that hierarchies are, by nature, masculine and that they maintain divisions of power and subordination in an organization (Acker, 1990; Ferguson, 1984).

The institutionalization and goal displacement model of organizational transformation (Gerth and Mills, 1946) holds that the emergence of a bureaucracy and an institutionalization in society is inevitable for any organization. Ferguson (1984) suggests that as organizations become bureaucratic, the function of the bureaucracy becomes the purpose of the organization. Some feminist scholars would argue that the institutionalization or bureaucratization of a women’s organization is a failure in and of itself (Feree and Martin, 1995). Feminist organizations that become bureaucratic can no longer be radical agents of political change (Ferguson, 1984). In this sense, one could argue that when a feminist organization ceases merely to fight bureaucracy and becomes bureaucratic itself, it has failed as a feminist organization by displaying gender divisions inherent in bureaucracy.

SFWR organized, from the beginning, as a hierarchy. Although the regional chapters of SFWR seemed to function autonomously, SFWR had a national coordinator (elected by the membership) and a board of directors. The regional chapters reported to the national office. The pressures for the SFWR organization to conform to the discourse of bureaucracy were evident internally as well as externally. Indeed, the letters from membership to the principals of SFWR point to an internal struggle between the feminist ideals of the founders and the increasing push toward a bureaucratic structure of the organization. In 1974, SFWR leadership was deciding between having an acting executive director and having a more collectivist steering committee to make day-to-day decisions. A letter from member, Kathy Bellman, advocates that having an executive director who could make autonomous decisions would cause great problems in the feminist organization (WAG 061/1)[1]. Barbara Freis, the outgoing SFWR treasurer, wrote in February, 1975 that she was “sorry to see SFWR lean toward corporate business means of survival” in lieu of feminist grassroots organizing (WAG 061/28).

Symbols

The second set of gendering processes is the social construction of symbols, artifacts, or images that justify or reinforce (or, less likely, oppose) the gender divisions (1990). These are the symbols that maintain societal masculinities or femininities. One of the greatest symbols of organizational power in most organizations is the allocation of financial resources.

Probably the greatest source of internal stress for the SFWR organization came over financial issues. An interview in the SFWR files indicates that the organization folded because of financial problems. Once the original \$25,000 Stern Fund grant ended, the membership numbers were not sufficient to support the organization. One interviewee estimates that the membership never grew higher than 1,100 members (SFWR Oral Collection), and a clip from a 1974 article in *Soho Weekly* lists the SFWR dues as \$1.00 per month (WAG 061/11). As early as 1974, a SFWR memo states that members will only be reimbursed for a portion of expenses. Another says that the national bank account was overdrawn in January, 1974 (WAG 061/28). More importantly, however, because no consensus existed among the organizing members as to how money should be spent or who should be in control of making spending decisions (WAG 061/27) it became symbolic of the power divisions in the organization. Several letters to SFWR leadership complain about the way money was spent and the lack of transparency in the finances.

Although there were numerous battles over the day-to-day spending and, particularly, who should control it, the greatest debate over finances seemed to center on the issue of the national office location. Great dissention was obvious over the location of the SFWR national office in Rockefeller Plaza, a beacon of male-dominated bureaucracy. This office was rented by SFWR, early in its existence at the much-lower-than-market rate of \$200 per month, reportedly to give the organization some visibility and legitimacy. A 1974 memo to SFWR Board Members states that leaders of the radical feminist movement saw the address at Rockefeller Plaza at the very low monthly rent as a way of “ripping off people who owe much in reparations”. Others, however, suggest that the address may “appear to be an elitist, bureaucratic one” that “turns off” some potential members committed to feminism (WAG 061/1). Also, when the financial situation became less stable, this high profile office space was symbolic of the spending of the organization was seen as a “sore thumb” (un-signed letter) and an extravagant expenditure of scarce resources (WAG 061/5).

Interactions

The third set of processes in the Acker framework is the interactions between people, particularly those “patterns that enact domination and submission” (Acker, 1990, p. 147) and “create alliances and exclusions” (Acker, 1992, p. 253). The analysis of the SFWR files suggests that these types of interactions were rampant in the organization.

(The) organization fell apart, splintered among ourselves (east and west group). New York was the focal point, had the office, people in SFO, felt they weren't really members of the organization. No budget, no plan for future action or a budget. Maybe this happened at the BOD [Board of Directors] meetings but nothing was ever resolved. Really serious personality issues. That, and a lack of trust and very forceful personalities – people who didn't get their way, didn't join back in when they saw their ideas wouldn't carry” (Interview by Sara Rapport with Kathleen Heenan 11/21/85: SFWR Oral History).

A June 26, 1975 letter from Susan Shanaberger, the national coordinator to a member, Kathleen Heenan, responded to the member's complaints about excessive phone bills (presumably in the national office). In a tersely-worded letter, Susan Shanaberger reminds Kathleen Heenan of the power differential between the two by saying, "you have voiced your complaints to me, and I have told you I do not believe the calls to be excessive. That should be sufficient to end the matter." She also reiterates the chain of command (hierarchy) in the organization should Heenan wish to pursue the matter further (SFWR files).

Identity work

The fourth process is that found in the individual's efforts to make sense of herself, and to construct her gendered identity and the corresponding appropriate behaviors as a member of the organization. This identity work is done to ensure a person's survival in the organization and serves to reinforce the gendered nature of the organization (Acker, 1992).

Weick (1979) defines organizing as "a consensually validated grammar" (Weick, 1979, p. 3) of rules and norms which become the foundation for interlocked behaviors through which the organization is constructed. This "grammar" constitutes both rules for how things should be done and, also, for interpreting what is done. Similarly, Ashcraft and Mumby (2004, p. 18) hold that organization is a language that has to be performed in a context where organization is the dominant mode of organizing. Language or communication is the action through which people construct the structure and meaning of organizing. This language, contextualized against the "larger social narratives" serve to form identities within and the structures of the organization.

In the case of SFWR, the "larger social narrative" seemed to form identities for the women of SFWR that were inconsistent with the organization they had created. The discourses of society limited how they saw themselves in relationship to others. As the organization grew, perhaps as a result of being composed of women with differing ability levels and agendas, the power imbalances became more pronounced.

Organizational logic

Organizational logic refers to implicit rules and underlying assumptions about what organizations *should* be. These underlying assumptions and practices construct most modern organizations (Clegg and Dunkerley, 1980). Organizational logic has both a material form and a symbolic form (Britton, 1997). The material form, work rules and policies of an organization are part of the gendered substructure and demonstrate the organizational logic at work. This underlying "common sense" or common construction is part of the processes of organizing (Acker, 1990).

This logic maintains the gender order in organizations and in society. All gendered organizations also have control mechanisms for women that reinforce the relative position of powerlessness of women in society (Acker and Van Houten, 1974). Additionally, central to this logic is a gender-neutral, disembodied worker. "Organizational logic is anchored in and helps to reproduce the fundamental structuring of industrial societies, in which the production of things and services for which money is exchanged is clearly separated in time, place, form of organization and conceptualization from the reproduction of human beings and everyday life." (Acker, 1995, p. 139). This gender neutrality is inherent in these organizational control

processes. The practice of gender neutrality obscures the gendering practices taking place in the organization. The continuation and reproduction of bureaucratic processes serve to maintain gender neutrality (Acker, 1992).

External pressures toward hierarchy and away from collective structures may be explicit, in the form of requirements from funding organizations (Acker, 1995). The initial grant from the Stern Family Fund was \$25,000, of which \$9,000 was designated to pay an executive director (SFWR files). It is unclear from the archives whether the Stern grant came with other conditions guiding the organization of SFWR. However, if the founders of SFWR had original ideas of a collective or truly democratic organization, that form of organization was effectively rendered impossible by the acceptance of this grant. Simply by creating the position of the executive director, the organization became hierarchical with one person in a position of power over others in the organization. Subsequently, SFWR was organized very traditionally. An undated document listing the Executive Board of SFWR shows a very hierarchical structure with several levels of management all falling under one national coordinator (WAG 061).

Shortall (2001) suggests that organizational logic holds that, in order to be a “real” organization, any organization must look like other “real” organizations. In the absence of a critical mass of feminist organizations institutional logic was likely anchored to masculinist forms of isomorphism. This logic was apparent in the SFWR members’ push for legitimacy as an organization. Many of the letters from SFWR members championing a bureaucratic organizational form suggest this as a necessity for a “real” organization. The location of the SFWR offices in Rockefeller Plaza is also suggested as a visible symbol that SFWR was a genuine organization.

Issues which are “women’s” issues are “organized out” of the organization in an effort to make the organization appear gender neutral. SFWR archives suggest transformation of the organization in the form of organizational maintenance. Organizational maintenance occurs when the primary goals of the organization are supplanted by the goal of maintaining organizational membership, funding or existence in some way (Feree and Martin, 1995). Later in its existence, SFWR leadership became increasingly concerned about raising funds to maintain the organization, even considering funding from Playboy Enterprises in 1974. In 1974, Nan Welmers asked SFWR Board Members to consider an offer of funding from Playboy Enterprises and what the ramifications of such funding would be (WAG 061/20)

A bumpy landing: the end of SFWR

Ferguson (1984) conceptualizes the argument about the success of a feminist organization as the debate between reform and revolution. In other words, she sees delineation between the goals of surviving in the world that exists (reform) and changing the world into something else altogether – what it should be (revolution). SFWR seemed to be, from the beginning much more interested in reform, working within the existing societal structures, than in revolution. Early planning notes indicate that one of the main objectives was to “create professionalism within the stewardess corps” (WAG 061/). This would indicate a need to gain legitimacy within the existing structure of the industry. Letters from stewardesses to SFWR speak of the need to develop “a code of ethics” and urge SFWR to focus efforts to legitimize the profession (WAG 061/). A newspaper article on the formation of SFWR indicates that a major

complaint leading to the formation of the organization was the fact that so few women held management positions in the airlines (WAG 061/11). Additionally, early planning letters indicate plans to work with existing unions and that SFWR members, specifically, and stewardesses, in general, should run for union offices to increase power in those organizations. A 1974 proposed statement for "Principles of Unity" states that SFWR will "work with our unions for as long as necessary prompting feminists to go into their airline unions as leaders" (WAG 061/).

Ferguson (1984) argues that bureaucratization of a feminist organization is not inevitable as a result of human nature. Non-bureaucratic organizations that become bureaucratic over time do so in response to outside pressures brought about by dependence on funding from hierarchical organizations. However, Zald (1988) noted that second-wave feminist organizations seemed to be able to better resist the pressures of the outside environment to change because of the structure of the organizations and the general strength of the movement supporting them. SFWR was not able to withstand these demands. Instead of finding support from the movement and the organization and opposing the pressures to conform, the first two national coordinators for SFWR left the organization as a response to the pressures. Founder Sandra Jarrell and Nan Frost Velmers, both reportedly left the organization in protest over the way it was operated. In Sandra Jarrell's case, the "organization wasn't doing what she had intended for it" (C. Hounsell interview with Sara Rapport, SFWR Oral Collection). There is some criticism of her leadership in an undated letter from a SFWR member that accuses her of trying to bypass the structure that was in place (WAG 061/).

Lessons learned

Even as the organization fought to change the gendered nature of the organizations in the airline industry, and even as its founders tried to create a genderless or, even, a female-gendered organization, they ended up creating a masculinist-influenced organization. Joan Acker (1995) might argue that SFWR was doomed from the outset. She posits that, because of the societal notion of organizing, the "truths" of organizational logic become embedded in the structure of them. In fact, the creation of organizations where gender does not "provide the subtext for arrangements of subordination" (Acker, 1990, p. 155) would require a radical change not only in the social structures of organizations, but in those of the greater societal context.

Perhaps it is the case that SFWR was doomed from its beginnings. SFWR leadership worked throughout the organization's existence to increase membership to all stewardesses. However, a small group of members from the SFO chapter possibly recognized the chances for survival would increase with a homogenous membership and suggested a change in focus. This letter goes on to propose changing the organization's emphasis from large membership ("We do not have to attract every flight attendant in the industry with a gripe") to a small, active group who share feminist ideals (WAG 061/1).

One of the greatest sources of disruption in the organization came as a result of unequal levels of knowledge and experience with the feminist movement and with organizing. Many SFWR members were college-educated and had experience in their labor unions or other feminist groups. Another significant portion was not highly educated and came to the organization without any experience. This inequity led to competitive and, often, nasty interchanges. A letter from Anne Sweeney to Tommie

Hutto Blake, both of whom apparently vied for the position of newsletter editor, is representative of this type of communication. In it, Sweeney, who subsequently resigned from active membership, accuses Hutto Blake, who became the newsletter editor, of feeling threatened and resentful of the abilities of other women. The letter also criticizes Hutto Blake's abilities in the areas of spelling and punctuation (WAG 061/27).

Some of the women involved with SFWR had loftier feminist goals than others. Some stewardesses joined the organization in response to specific and personal complaints with their own airline. One letter to the founders points to a concern about women having to sign their complete legal name on a liquor form while men did not. Another core group of SFWR members, however, wanted the organization to make larger social changes in the airline industry. These women seemed to be constantly at odds with the members who did not share their lofty aspirations. A letter from one active SFWR member suggests that one of the regional leaders "feels that not having to wear nail polish is a great accomplishment", but that the organization needed to focus on "real" areas of improvement (WAG 061/4).

SFWR had to form its own organization for the issues of stewardesses (women) to be addressed by other organizations in the highly (male) gendered industry. However, the societal pressure and the women's understanding of what is "real" and valued in an organization pushed them to create an organization that was as highly (male-) gendered as the organizations from which they were escaping. Many in the organization never saw SFWR as a "real" organization because of the underlying organizational logic that was directing what the organization should be.

Even if the organization did, on the surface, look different than other explicitly male-gendered organizations, the same underlying organizational logic manifested itself in similar organizational structure. The lives of the women of SFWR and the societal context within which SFWR existed were already established in a hierarchical world. The discourses of society limited how they saw themselves in relationship to others. As the organization grew, perhaps as a result of being composed of women with differing ability levels and agendas, the power imbalances became more pronounced. When this was compounded by the financial pressures, the internal drive to bureaucratize became greater. This led to bickering and harsh words with women leaving the organization rather than fighting to change it. The goals of the individuals involved became more important than the collective goals of SFWR. More importantly, behaviors that were constructed as being consistent with the feminist movement early in SFWR's existence were translated as being divisive and destructive at its end. SFWR members who were interviewed characterized the later period as being fraught with personality issues, lack of trust and inactivity. Letters from SFWR members, written during this time period, make accusations about other members that would echo the social attributions given to women who did not perform the stereotypical female role. In a group of communications from this period, SFWR members give each other a variety of monikers including, "bitch," "petty little bitch," "difficult to get along with," "hard to deal with," and "a pathetic, fucked up person." The organization could not function in spite of the societal discourses but, because of its feminist roots, also could not function within them.

Acker (1995) does suggest things that improve the chance of success for feminist efforts. Small feminist groups with homogeneous backgrounds have a better chance for

simple survival. As evidenced above, this was not the case for SFWR. She also suggests that change projects, such as SFWR, should target a finite set of issues (2006). The SFWR organization began targeting very broad issues of working conditions and discrimination in the industry. As a result, there was often disagreement about exactly what issues SFWR should be concerned with. Finally, Acker offers that change projects should focus on combining inside support with the outside social movement and legislative support (Acker, 2006). In this regard, SFWR was relatively successful. The organization seemed to have support from the second-wave feminist movement throughout its history, with visible support from key figures in that movement (including Gloria Steinem and Betty Friedan).

Improving on Acker's framework

Approaching two decades since it was first published, Acker's framework remains the most theoretically sound framework for analyzing gendered organizations. However, we humbly suggest some conceptual thoughts in an effort to improve on the theory.

The gendering of an organization is not just an internal phenomenon. It is also an interaction of external context, other organizations (i.e. funding organizations, suppliers), customers, government, etc. The framework leaves little place for analysis of the role of external entities in constructing the gendered substructure. Interaction with other people is subsumed in the third set of processes – interactions between people. However, the influence and interaction with other organizations, a big part of the SFWR story is not a part of this framework. SFWR seemed to be vulnerable to the pressures of organizational isomorphism through its interaction with other organizations such as the original funding agency, the unions and the airlines. Acker (2006) speaks to this issue in later work by suggesting that successful change projects must have internal activism combined with legislative support and coordination with a great social movement.

Acker's framework firmly positions gender as a social construction. The five processes result in the way gender is done by people in organizations. More recent work on gender in organizations presents a nuanced view of gender, not as a static construction, but as a performance which, as a reiteration of a set of norms (or underlying logic), becomes an act in the present to conceal the norms it is reiterating (Butler, 1990). Gherardi and Poggio (2007, p. 31) view gender, not as a "unitary and definitive" product of social construction, but as an ongoing performance that an individual constantly constructs and reconstructs against multiple societal (or organizational) discourses.

Theoretical or conceptual developments to this framework could include investigation of how the interaction with external organizations affects the gendered substructure and could re-frame gendered organizational analysis using a performance view of gender. As has been argued elsewhere (Dye and Mills), an important dimension of Acker's work would be to see the five processes as historically framed – viewed at a particular point in time but perhaps usefully tracked over time. This paper, for example, examined a 1970s organization. It would also be interesting for future research to examine a current feminist or all-female organization. Work could examine whether the explicit organization practices have changed to such a degree that these processes (i.e. division of labor and the culture) are different. A focus on (historical) change could also help deal with the issue of performativity and the contextual factors that shape potentially successful performances.

Note

1. The files of the Stewardesses for Women's Rights constitute the Wagner Collection 061, hereafter referred to as WAG 061/[folder number]. The audiotapes are cataloged as Tamiment/Wagner Archives Main Collection (Oral Histories 12), hereafter referred to as the SFWR Oral Collection. We also consulted related files of the Independent Union of Flight Attendants (Wagner Collection 200) – IUFA Files, and the Transport Workers Union of America (Wagner Collection 285) – TWU files.

References

- Acker, J. (1990), "Hierarchies, jobs, bodies: a theory of gendered organizations", *Gender and Society*, Vol. 4 No. 2, pp. 139-58.
- Acker, J. (1992), "Gendering organizational theory", in Mills, A.J. and Tancred, P. (Eds), *Gendering Organizational Analysis*, Sage, Newbury Park, CA, pp. 248-60.
- Acker, J. (1995), "Feminist goals and organizing processes", in Feree, M.M. and Martin, P.Y. (Eds), *Feminist Organizations: Harvest of the New Women's Movement*, Temple University Press, Philadelphia, PA.
- Acker, J. (2006), "Inequality regimes: gender, class, and race in organizations", *Gender & Society*, Vol. 20 No. 4, pp. 441-64.
- Acker, J. and Van Houten, D. (1974), "Differential recruitment and control: the sex structuring of organizations", *Administrative Science Quarterly*, Vol. 19 No. 2, pp. 152-63.
- Ashcraft, K.L. and Mumby, D.K. (2004), *Reworking Gender: A Feminist Communicology of Organization*, Sage, Thousand Oaks, CA.
- Britton, D.M. (1997), "The epistemology of the gendered organization", *Gender and Society*, Vol. 14 No. 3, pp. 418-34.
- Britton, D.M. (1999), "Cat fights and gang fights: preference for work in a male-dominated organization", *The Sociological Quarterly*, Vol. 40 No. 3, pp. 455-74.
- Butler, J. (1990), *Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of the Identity*, Routledge, New York, NY.
- Clegg, S. and Dunkerley, D. (1980), *Organization, Class, Control*, Routledge and Kegan Paul, London.
- Dilthey, W. (1976), *Selected Writings*, Cambridge University Press, London.
- Feree, M.M. and Martin, P.Y. (1995), "Doing the work of the movement: feminist organizations", in Feree, M.M. and Martin, P.Y. (Eds), *Feminist Organizations: Harvest of the New Women's Movement*, Temple University Press, Philadelphia, PA.
- Ferguson, K. (1984), *The Feminist Case Against Bureaucracy*, Temple University Press, Philadelphia, PA.
- Gadamer, H.G. (1975) in Barden, G. and Cumming, J. Transl. (Eds), *Truth and Method*, Seabury, New York, NY.
- Gerth, H.J. and Mills, C.W. (Eds.) (1946), *From Max Weber: Essays in Sociology*, Oxford University Press, New York, NY.
- Gherardi, S. and Poggio, B. (2007), *Gendertelling in Organizations: Narratives from Male-dominated Environments*, Copenhagen Business School Press, Liber, Copenhagen.
- Grant, D., Hardy, C., Oswick, C. and Putnam, L.L. (2004), "Introduction: organizational discourse: exploring the field", in Grant, D., Hardy, C., Oswick, C. and Putnam, L.L. (Eds), *The Sage Handbook of Organizational Discourse*, Sage, London.

-
- Hirschman, E.C. (1990), "Secular immortality and the American ideology of affluence", *Journal of Consumer Research*, Vol. 17 No. 1, pp. 31-42.
- Klemm, D.E. (1983), *The Hermeneutical Theory of Paul Ricoeur*, Associated University Presses, East Brunswick, NJ.
- McLaren, P.G. and Mills, A.J. (2008), "A product of 'his' time? Exploring the construct of the ideal manager in the Cold War era", *Journal of Management History*, Vol. 14 No. 4, pp. 386-403.
- Mills, A.J. (1998), "Cockpits, hangars, boys and galleys: corporate masculinities and the development of British Airways", *Gender, Work and Organization*, Vol. 5 No. 3, pp. 172-88.
- New York University Libraries (2005), *Guide to the Records of Stewardesses for Women's Rights*, New York, NY.
- Pini, B. and Crawford, M. (2006) in Jefferson, T., Lord, L., Nelson, N. and Preston, A. (Eds), "The Australian parliament: a gendered organization", *Changes. Challenge. Choices. Conference Proceedings from the Inaugural International Women and Leadership Conference, Freemantle, Australia*, pp. 245-56.
- Prasad, A. (2002), "The contest over meaning: hermeneutics as an interpretive methodology for understanding texts", *Organizational Research Methods*, Vol. 5 No. 1, pp. 12-33.
- Prasad, A. and Mir, R. (2002), "Digging deep for meaning: a critical hermeneutic analysis of CEO letters to shareholders in the oil industry", *Journal of Business Communication*, Vol. 39 No. 1, pp. 92-116.
- Prasad, P. (2005), *Crafting Qualitative Research*, M.E. Sharpe, Armonk, NY.
- Price, K. (2008), "Keeping the dancers in check: the gendered organization of stripping work in the lion's den", *Gender & Society*, Vol. 22 No. 3, pp. 367-89.
- Shortall, S. (2001), "Women in the field: women, farming and organizations", *Gender, Work and Organization*, Vol. 8 No. 2, pp. 164-81.
- West, C. and Zimmerman, D.H. (1987), "Doing gender", *Gender and Society*, Vol. 1 No. 2, pp. 125-51.
- Weick, K.E. (1979), *The Social Psychology of Organizing*, Addison-Wesley Publishing, Reading, MA.
- Zald, M.N. (1988), *The Trajectory of Social Movements in America, Research in Social Movements, Conflicts, and Change*, JAI Press, Greenwich, CT.

About the authors

Donna Boone Parsons is a Lecturer at the University of North Carolina Asheville and a PhD candidate at the Sobey School of Business, Saint Mary's University, Halifax, Nova Scotia. Donna Boone Parsons is the corresponding author and can be contacted at: dparsons@unca.edu

Kathy Sanderson is an Instructor at Lakehead University and a PhD student at Sobey School of Business, Saint Mary's University, Halifax, Nova Scotia.

Jean Helms Mills is a Professor of Management in the Sobey School of Business. She has authored or co-authored seven books, including *Making Sense of Organizational Change* (Routledge, 2003) and *Understanding Organizational Change* (2009).

Albert J. Mills is Director of the Sobey PhD (Management). He is the author of over 20 books, including *Sex, Strategy and the Stratosphere* (Routledge, 2006).